
BUYER'S BRIEFING · 2026

The Charter Buyer's Guide

A decision framework for buying private aviation — pricing, safety, and the contract terms that matter — decomposed for the first-time flyer and the once-burned.

PREPARED BY

Liam · charterwithliam.com

CLASSIFICATION

Buyer Education

SCOPE

On-Demand Charter

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Private aviation is sold through a fog of jargon, opaque quotes, and offers that are too good to be true. This briefing clears it. It frames the three ways private flights are purchased and when each pays off, decomposes a charter quote into the cost drivers underneath it, and supplies the safety and contract questions that separate certificated operators from middlemen. Read it once and you will evaluate any quote with the discipline of a seasoned buyer.

Three WAYS TO FLY PRIVATE	Up to 75% EMPTY-LEG DISCOUNT VS. RETAIL	7.5% FEDERAL EXCISE TAX ON CHARTER	< 25 hrs ANNUAL THRESHOLD FAVORING ON- DEMAND
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ORIENTATION

00 Who this is for

This is for the traveler who wants the real economics — not the brochure.

You are weighing a private flight — perhaps for the first time, perhaps because the last one left a bad taste. You have seen the eye-watering quotes, the suspiciously cheap “deals,” and the wall of terminology standing between you and a simple yes. This briefing is written to dismantle that wall.

What follows is the analysis an honest advisor would give a friend: what a charter actually costs and why, how to read a quote line by line, the questions that distinguish accredited operators from brokers reselling your flight, and how repositioning — empty legs — lets a flexible buyer fly at a fraction of retail. No upsell. Just the structure beneath the price.

01 The three ways to fly private

Nearly every private flight is bought through one of three models. The disciplined choice follows from how many hours you actually fly in a year — not from how often you imagine you will.

The models differ in capital commitment, cost structure, and who carries the risk of an under-used asset. On-demand charter pushes that risk onto the operator; jet cards and fractional shift convenience and guaranteed access onto your balance sheet — at a premium you pay whether or not you draw on it.

EXHIBIT 1 The three purchasing models, compared

	ON-DEMAND CHARTER	JET CARD	FRACTIONAL
Structure	Book a single trip on whatever aircraft is available.	Prepay for a block of hours at a fixed hourly rate.	Purchase a share of a specific aircraft; fly a set allotment.
Capital upfront	None — pay per trip.	\$100K-\$500K deposit, typical.	\$400K-\$2M+ buy-in, plus monthly fees.
Best fit	A handful of trips a year; flexible routing.	25-50+ hours a year; want price certainty.	200+ hours a year; want guaranteed availability.
Hourly economics	Lowest sticker; varies trip to trip.	Fixed, with a convenience premium embedded.	Highest all-in, but the most predictable.
The trade-off	Price and aircraft change every time.	You pay for access you may not use.	Capital tied up; depreciation is yours.

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The honest default

Below roughly 25 hours a year, on-demand charter almost always wins. Cards and fractional programs monetize certainty and convenience — charges you absorb in full whether or not you ever call on them.

02 What actually drives the price

A charter quote is not a figure handed down from the cockpit. It is the sum of a few cost levers — identify them and a fair price becomes predictable.

Decompose the quote and you can estimate a fair number before a broker ever sends one. Seven levers do most of the work:

- ◆ **Aircraft category.** Turboprop → light → midsize → super-mid → heavy → ultra-long-range. Each step up roughly doubles the hourly burn.
- ◆ **Flight time, not distance.** You pay for hours aloft. Headwinds, routing, and fuel stops all add billable time.
- ◆ **Repositioning.** If the aircraft is not based where you depart, you fund its flight to you — empty — and often its flight home.
- ◆ **Daily minimums.** Most operators bill a 1–2 hour minimum per day, so a 30-minute hop still costs an hour or more.
- ◆ **Crew and overnights.** Multi-day trips carry crew hotels, per diems, and duty-time limits that can force a second crew.
- ◆ **Peak demand and short notice.** Holidays, marquee events, and sub-48-hour bookings command surcharges against finite supply.
- ◆ **Airport fees.** Landing, ramp, and de-icing charges vary widely. Teterboro and Aspen are not Toledo.

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Levers that move in your favor

Flexible dates, a round trip that keeps the aircraft with you (avoiding two repositioning legs), and departing from a field where aircraft are already based all pull the quote down. Ask for them by name.

03 How to read a quote

A transparent quote itemizes what you are buying. An opaque one folds the markup into a single, unverifiable number. Read the structure before the bottom line.

Seven lines carry the substance — and the surprises:

- ◆ **Aircraft and tail number.** A real quote names the specific aircraft, or at minimum the exact make and model — not “midsize jet or similar.”
- ◆ **Occupied vs. total flight time.** Confirm whether repositioning legs are itemized or absorbed into one figure.
- ◆ **Federal Excise Tax (FET).** 7.5% on domestic charter. If it is absent, ask — it is not optional, only sometimes deferred to the invoice.
- ◆ **Fuel surcharge.** A line item, not a moving target. Ask whether it is capped.
- ◆ **Landing, handling, and segment fees.** Immaterial alone, meaningful together. They should be listed, not marked “TBD.”
- ◆ **Catering and ground transport.** Frequently pass-through. Establish what is included before assuming it is.
- ◆ **Cancellation terms.** The single most consequential paragraph in the document. Read it before you read the price.

CAUTION

The “all-in” that isn’t

A single flat number with no breakdown — and a broker who waves off itemization — is a signal to slow down. What you cannot see, you cannot verify, and cannot negotiate.

DUE DILIGENCE

04 The safety questions that matter

Most buyers never establish whether they are speaking with the operator that holds the certificate or a broker several steps removed. Five questions settle it.

A certificated operator answers all five without friction. Hesitation or deflection is itself the answer.

- ◆ **“Who holds the operating certificate for this flight?”** You want the Part 135 operator’s name — the entity legally accountable for the flight.
- ◆ **“Is this aircraft on that operator’s certificate?”** Brokering an aircraft that is not is a material red flag.
- ◆ **“What is your third-party safety rating?”** ARGUS, Wyvern, and IS-BAO are the recognized audits. Ask for the current tier.
- ◆ **“What are the pilots’ hours and type currency?”** Two qualified, type-current pilots — not one, and not a contractor flying an unfamiliar aircraft.
- ◆ **“What is the insurance liability limit?”** You may ask to be named as an additional insured.

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What a credible answer sounds like

Certificate holder, safety tier, and insurance limits delivered instantly and in writing. A legitimate operator keeps these at hand and shares them without being pressed.

THE INEFFICIENCY

05 How empty legs work

Repositioning is a structural inefficiency in charter — and the single largest source of discount available to a flexible buyer.

When an aircraft completes a one-way trip, it frequently must reposition empty to its next assignment. The operator funds that leg regardless, so any revenue improves on none — which is why empty legs clear at discounts of up to 75% against retail. The price of entry is flexibility.

- ◆ **They run on the aircraft's schedule.** The more you can flex on date, time, and exact airport, the more legs open up.
- ◆ **They are perishable.** A leg exists only until the aircraft moves. Many surface 24–72 hours out and vanish quickly.
- ◆ **They can change or cancel.** If the originating paid trip moves, the empty leg moves with it. Keep a backup for anything truly time-critical.
- ◆ **Corridors concentrate supply.** LA–Vegas, South Florida–Northeast, and New York–Florida generate the most repositioning.

ADVANTAGE

How to capture them in practice

Give an advisor your home airports and the routes you fly, then let them filter the firehose. Matched alerts outperform refreshing a public empty-leg page — the best legs are spoken for before they are ever posted.

06 Pre-booking due diligence

Ten items to clear before capital changes hands. If you cannot tick all ten, you have a question to ask — not a deposit to send.

☐ Confirmed the Part 135 operator that holds the certificate for the flight.

☐ Verified the aircraft is on that operator's certificate.

☐ Obtained the third-party safety rating (ARGUS / Wyvern / IS-BAO).

☐ Received an itemized quote — flight time, FET, fuel, and fees all listed.

☐ Confirmed whether repositioning legs are included in the price.

☐ Read the cancellation and change terms in full.

☐ Established what is included: catering, ground transport, Wi-Fi, de-icing.

☐ Confirmed pilot count, type currency, and insurance limits.

☐ Requested flexible dates or a round trip to reduce cost.

☐ Secured the operator's direct contact for the day of travel.

ENGAGEMENT

Have a trip in mind?

Send your route and dates. I will structure the right flight at the right price — and surface the empty legs that match before they clear.

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